A Thousand Scars and A Hundred Lives
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A Thousand Scars and A Hundred Lives

by sanguinedreamer

Summary

Mydei fights his god and breaks. Unfortunately for him, his curse of immortality ensures he can never rest, and does nothing for his pain.

Hurt/comfort between Phainon and Mydei for anyone else craving it after the quest.

Notes

The first chapter of this is mostly hurt, though there is a bit of relief at the end. Chapter two (likely the final one) will be more focused on comfort. Use this information wisely.

This fic is considerably more graphic than Honkai Star Rail itself, but I don't think it enters gore or archive warning territory. If you disagree, let me know in the comments.

Contains spoilers for all of 3.0 (that I've encountered, anyway). I do not read leaks or include them, so you won't find them here. Please don't mention leaks to me in the comments. Also, some of the dialogue is taken directly from the game.

Finally, this was written in 3.0, before either main character's release. I rarely write about characters so early because I struggle when there's so little canon info. I did as much research as I could, but it almost certainly will not be canon-compliant with later patches. A particular note is that Mydei's kit is not yet released, so I used my best judgment.

See the end of the work for more notes

Intent to Kill

In many ways, the fight against Nikador is the fight that Mydei has been preparing for his entire life.

Despite his bravado, he understands Phainon's hesitation. The towering figure before them is the most feared god in their world, the embodiment of Strife itself. Killing any titan is an intimidating prospect; killing Nikador, then, is a trulyoverwhelming one. But Mydei has never had the luxury of hesitation. And so, he fights.

It is a good battle. Despite her strange choice of weapon, Stelle is surprisingly strong. She's clever and strategic, too, despite how odd her words can be. Phainon is powerful and precise, a trained swordsman who understands Mydei's combat style. They complement each other well, covering for each other's weaknesses and able to predict where the other will be. And if Phainon doesn't like the risky attacks he sometimes prefers… well, the battle is too fast-paced to linger on the disapproving frown of the other Chrysos Heir.

Finally, with a crushing blow from Mydei's fist, Nikador, Titan of Strife, shudders and collapses to the ground. The god lies defeated, their mechanical body reduced to nothing more than a heap of scrap. The sounds of combat recede, and a loaded, expectant silence hangs in the air.

There is a moment when Mydei thinks—*hopes*, perhaps—that the battle is truly won. Next to him, Phainon exhales loudly, undoubtedly preparing to give some foolish speech. Mydei smirks. But his expression immediately turns to a grimacewhen he sees a golden light emanate from the titan's corpse, and the pieces of their body start to move.

Within seconds, Nikador glows a blinding gold. The light fades, leaving behind theirreformed body.

"Immortal wretch… how amusing." There's a certain dark humor to it. Of course his god, corrupted as they are, shares his curse.

The Blade of Fury soars up to the dark sky. The titan’s massive weapon hangs overhead menacingly, poised to fall at any moment. The threat to Okhema is undeniable.

As always, Phainon is far more vocal than he needs to be. "The souls of war are amassing in the skies above Kremnos... surging toward the Blade of Fury! They have no intention of winning the fight. Instead, they're using death after death to temper their blade. Even with a hundred deaths, they've resolved to pierce through Kephale's body!"

Stelle nods grimly. It seems they all understand the danger. Even so, Mydei suspects he’s the only one who understands what must be done to stop it.

He scoffs. "All their honor is gone. How did the god of our tribe fall so low?" Nikador roars, but he ignores the noise and turns to Phainon instead. "Deliverer, here is your moment. I'll hold them off here and keep them from wielding the Blade of Fury. You need to head back and notify the two demigods."

As expected, his rival doesn’t respond well to his order. "Are you out of your mind, facing the Titan alone?! I'm staying, too.” He turns to their other ally, hand over his heart beseechingly. “Stelle, please—"

“Get lost!” Mydei roars. "Do you have to make me say this?"

Perhaps Stelle will not pick up on his meaning, but he is certain Phainon will. The other man knows how he feels about discussing his curse of immortality. Surely, Mydei does not have to lay out the obvious: he can be killed, and Phainon cannot.

The expression on Phainon’s face and his slightly parted lips suggests that even now, he intends to argue. Stubborn fool. Mydei changes tactics. He turns his back to the others and approaches the titan, speaking in a slightly calmer tone as he does."I must stay here, not for Okhema's safety, but to settle the score with my god. Even if immortality is a curse, it shouldn't be used so despicably."

It is the correct move. His fellow Chrysos Heir makes an audible noise of understanding. For all his flaws, Phainon understands honor. Perhaps more than that, he understands *vengeance* .

He adds, "Go, Deliverer. Your battlefield lies elsewhere."

Even turned away from Phainon, he can feel the weight of the man’s gaze. Something unspoken hangs between them.

"...Stay strong. Try not to get killed too many times."

The sound of retreating footsteps echoes as his two companions leave hastily. If all goes well, they will make it to Okhema with enough time to warn Aglaea and Tribbie of Nikador’s plan. If anyone can protect that city from the Strife Titan’s attack, it will be them.

"Finally, some peace," Mydei says, well aware that the others can still hear him. His words are, at least in part, for their benefit. They should leave this place knowing he is prepared for the fight ahead. "You and I—two warriors rejected by death. Is there any contest more fair than this?"

Mydei gazes once more upon his god. This time, the sight fills him with profound disgust. Once, Nikador’s mighty form left him in awe, made him proud to follow the most powerful of the titans. Now, the immortal mechanical being repulses him.

"Come forth! The king who has never claimed his throne, against the god who has fallen from grace. How perfectly matched we are!" He grins fiercely, staring directly into the empty face of Nikador. "Let's battle till the world's final breath!"

There is little room for thought when battling a god, at least a god as powerful as the Titan of Strife. There is only instinct. Nikador does not hesitate, does notslowly ramp up their attacks. They immediately heave their lance at Mydei. He evades the blade narrowly thanks to his battle-honed reflexes.The titan’s weapon shatters the stone floor where he’d just been standing as he scrambles from the spot.

“Not bad,” Mydei grins, drawing his own spear. “Finally, an actual challenge.”

His body twists and dodges and lunges faster than his conscious mind can work. They are evenly matched, both struggling to land a blow. It’s exhilarating to face a titan in one-on-one combat and be able to keep up. Despite the seriousness of the situation, he finds himself smiling. He’s having *fun* .

The stalemate continues. Mydei rolls, deflects, punches, and runs, seeking any opening he might find. Gradually, his body slows, tiring from the endless battle. He is fighting much more defensively than he normally would, but even this drains him. If only he can land a fatal blow, he might buy himself a minute or two to recuperate.

Finally, Mydei senses his opportunity. He jumps back as Nikador sweeps their lance in a giant arc. It tears against the stone floor of the arena, spewing fire in its wake. Before the flames can recede, he rushes to take advantage of the opening. Searing heat burns his feet but he ignores the pain and leaps forward, spear in hand. With all the strength he can summon, he thrusts the weapon into the titan.

His blade sings as it slides smoothly into Nikador's metal chest. It pierces the place the titan's heart would be, had they possessed one.

The monstrous creation stumbles back and lets out a pained, vicious cry. Mydei roars his own cry of victory in response. Adrenaline pulses through his veins as he drives his weapon deeper into the god’s wound. *This* is the glory of battle. It is blood, ashes, and the thrum of power running through his body. Few who are not Kremnoans truly comprehend this majesty of strife. To Mydei, nothing in this world is simpler.Honor and glory emerge when fear transforms into the will to fight, to protect.

Once again, the titan’s body falters and crumbles. Mydei wrenches his spear free of the pile, breathing heavily from the exertion of the kill. Even as he silently celebrates his victory over Nikador, he assesses the state of his own body. He’s bleeding from several wounds he hadn’t even noticed, and his limbs are starting to feel heavier from tiredness. He knows he’s already

healing, and that his stamina is slowly replenishing, but he’s also aware that his limited self-regeneration abilities cannot possibly keep up with the pace of this combat. How long can he fight?

He has less time to savor the titan’s defeat than he anticipates. After only a minute or so, Nikador glows gold and reassembles once more. Though Mydei never truly let his guard down, he is still startled by how quickly the god manages to raise their blade and attack.

Mydei dodges the lance at the last second. For a brief moment, he thinks he’s managed to escape. Then, he’s hit with unbelievable pain like nothing he’s ever felt before as the tip tears into his side.

It’s like being crushed by the full weight of Georios’ mountain or the force of Phagousa’s sea. He’s thrown back, landing so hard all the breath is knocked from his lungs. His body scrapes excruciatingly across the floor of their arena before he comes to a stop. The gash in his torso is agonizing. When his hand finds the wound, he grimaces at the gory mess of rent flesh. He can feel his own blood soaking his pants and cooling.

There is no time to waste. He must move, before the titan has the chance to attack once again. But without air, his body struggles to respond. He’s almost managed to roll over when he hears Nikador’s cry of victory. He looks up just in time to seethe god’s lance run him through.

All goes dark.

This was not the first time Mydei had rushed to his death.

He's well aware that the people of Okhema, sheltered as they are by their sleeping titan, find the very idea barbaric. Even now, they look on the Kremnoans in their city with distrust, fearful of anyone who charges gladly into battle. In contrast, the descendants of Castor Kremnos understand that they face their possible demise every time they draw weapons, and eagerly embrace the risk.

For Mydei, though, the certainty with which he accepts his body’s destruction is unmatched even among his people. How could it not be? His

father’s acts had unintentionally ensured that death would inevitably find him, and yet eternally evade him.

This is not the time to think of of death, of patricide and betrayed duty. Yet in the darkness, they are the only thoughts that come. Mydei remembers the outrage and horror on his father’s face as he impaled him on his spear. The blood—his blood, the blood of his ancestors—had gushed hot and thick over his arms. The iron tang had been nauseating, intoxicating. It reminded him of the tales of ancient Kremnoans, drinking the blood of defeated enemies. He’d had to stop himself from laughing in front of his warriors at the thought *this is nothing like pomegranate juice* . And then there was his advisor, urging him to take his rightful throne in this decaying fortress. No matter what the man said, Mydei remained steadfast. The blood of his father still clung to him, sticky as it dried and reeking of death.

Mydei opens his eyes.

The blood is his own, pooling around his still body. The death is his own, too. A false death. He balances a hand on the stone and pushes himself to a crouching position. His hand finds his discarded spear, and he rises to his full height once again.

“You won’t be rid of me that easily,” he laughs. After all, there is no audience now, just the mad god facing him, his distorted reflection. “I said we would battle til the end of the world, if that’s what it takes!”

Nearly every inch of him is covered in wounds. There are slashes from Nikador’s blade and flying debris. Abrasions mar his elbows and back from where he had skidded across the arena floor. The hole in his side is slowly closing, but the blood flow hasn’t quite stopped yet. No matter. He hefts his spear and surges forward as steadily as he can.

After their deaths, their fight grows more desperate.

The joy of their earlier battle evaporates. Where before they were evenly matched and rarely landed a hit, now both are wounded and opportunistic. When he blocks Nikador’s lance, the bones in his arms seem to grind together, and his muscles cry out in pain. Every punch that he lands on the

titan reminds him of the state of his hands—skeleton and sinew decimated from the force of attacking a steel god.

Nikador falls at his hands twice more before Mydei makes another major mistake. This time, the sweeping lance attack takes him by surprise. He's pummeled by the blade and engulfed in flames.

He dies.

He opens his eyes once more to that same cursed battlefield. Hecannot die.

He kills.

Every fiber of his being screams in agony. Every part feels like it has been destroyed, and is slowly reassembling, coming together inelegantly as the titan before him. His body seems like it is not his own. It is a prison he cannot escape.

Mydei loses all sense of time. The battle might have gone on for minutes, or hours, or perhaps even days. In the perpetual darkness of the evernight, it's nearly impossible to tell. There are only the constants of exertion and steel ringing against steel.

He screams until his throat is shredded and he cannot make a sound. But the vocal cords start to mend, and his cries once more echo across the battlefield. Even when he cannot speak, there is the eternal clamor of blades and Nikador's war cry, a sound chilling enough to reduce most mortals to terror.

His clothing is stained and the floor is slick with his own golden blood. No matter; his body keeps producing it, to make up for what he's lost. He can't die. He can't escape. The smell makes his stomach turn.

When Nikador falls, he spares a second to wonder about the others. Did they make it back to Okhema? Is the city safe?

Where are they?

… did Phainon truly abandon him here?

It’s been so long—days, it must’ve been. *Weeks*. Why is it taking them so long to find a way tocounter Nikador’s immortal form?

Unless there is no solution. Unless he is meant to fight the titan forever, as he promised.

He is capable. This proves he is. He can fight for an eternity.

When he dies, his eyes fall shut for a few merciful moments. Calm, still darkness surrounds him, and the ache in his body subsides. Then, his eyes snap open again. He must fight. The world depends on it. His curse, his title, his destiny demands it.

He’s witnessed Castorice guiding souls to death. He’s seen how the overwhelming fear fades, how their eyelids slip shut and their lips slowly curl up to form a peaceful smile. Are mortals wrong to fear death, in the end? Perhaps death is the ultimate bliss, or at least the ultimate relief.

It’s the thing he will always be denied.

Release is not an option. His only choice is rage.

Anger surges through him just as hot and heady as the golden blood of a Chrysos Heir. Sorrow and regrets and bitterness blend in, too, but he feels mostly rage. His god is the cause of his every problem. The ruin of his family, his people, his life… all suffering wrought by the titan before him. He’s disgusted by them, this pathetic war god so frightened of death and defeat that they would become an immortal abomination.

So he fights. He fights on and on, his hatred and anger powering him no matter how many times he falls.

Pain, death, rage, war, Nikador’s battle cry, blood, death, resurrection, combat, agony, endless battle…

Maybe this is destiny. From the moment of his birth—before, even—everything has pointed to this. The Sea of Souls, the curse… his

transformation into the perfect weapon to fight Nikador. A whole existence of strife to face Strife. Their fates intertwined, one and the same.

Madness for madness.

At some point, a red fog had crept in, unnoticed. He clings to rage to fend off the despair and madness. It is his greatest weapon. He must become the weapon. Rage is the weapon and so is he and he is rage...

—dei

The noise doesn't register. The battlefield is full of noise; he hardly notices any of it now. He runs at Nikador once more, landing a solid hit against his leg.

Mydei

This time, he hears the sound, and pauses for a split second. There is something familiar about it. But it doesn't come from the titan, so it is not important. He leaps into the air and scales the mechanical god. When he reaches the shoulder, he jumps and punches the titan's headpiece. They toss him to the ground with a roar. It feels like his kneecap shatter on impact.

"Mydei!"

It's a voice. A human voice. He turns his head toward the unexpected sound. Two figures run toward him, weapons drawn. One looks vaguely familiar, with short dark hair and strange clothes, and the other…

"Phainon?" he whispers. His voice sounds wrecked. The red fog recedes.

"Fuck, you're…" He meets the man's intense blue gaze, and feels something new. *Relief*. "Mydei, watch out!"

Mydei. Oh, right—that's his name. His vision clears a bit more.

Thankfully, the other man—Dan Heng, he remembers now—is impressively fast, and manages to block the titan's blade from plunging into Mydei's heart.

“Thanks,” he says, clambering to his feet despite the ruined knee. It will fix itself soon. “Now let’s kill this thing!”

The titan, clearly unprepared for their onslaught, falls to their coordinated attacks. This time, Dan Heng lands the final blow, his spear hitting so hard that Nikador’s body fractures under it.

The temporary death of the titan gives them a moment to regroup.

Phainon wastes no time. “Mydei, you look…” He shakes his head. “Never mind. To make a long story short, Stelle and Castorice are researching how to break Nikador’s immortality. Dan Heng and I are here to help you fight.”

“Reinforcements, huh?” Mydei rolls his shoulder. It still feels wrecked, but he thinks he can swing his fist with it. “Well, thank you. But it wasn’t really necessary. I was managing on my own.”

“Ha! I bet you were!”

“I do appreciate it, though. Just… try to stay back. Believe me when I say that even a single hit from the titan can kill.”

Dan Heng speaks up. “We’ll take up the rear. We should all focus on fighting defensively. There’s not much else we can do until the others find out how to strip away Nikador’s immortality.”

“Good idea,” Phainon nods. “We’ll avoid taking any major damage and make sure we keep them occupied.” He elbows Mydei lightly. “That includes you, too, my friend.”

“Hmph, we’ll see about that.” Mydei grasps his spear and aims it at his god’s towering form. “I’m determined to face this thing to the end. No matter what it costs.”

Soothing Waters

Chapter Notes

> Chapter 2 is up! Please note the rating change as this fic now contains a lot of smut!
>
> I was rushing to get this out before 3.1 drops since the patch will probably ruin all my attempts at making the story canon-compliant. Please note the new tags and enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The moment they return to Okhema, Mydei informs the others that he's going to rest. Their expressions range from curious to deeply concerned. Mydei turns to the city to avoid them.

"Rest up, De! Feel better soon!" says Tribbie. Despite their typical childish enthusiasm, the demigod sounds exhausted. He wonders how much operating the Century Gate took out of them.

"Mydei, are you…?" It's Phainon, of course. "I've never seen you look so —"

After everything today, he's far too drained for the other man's questions. "I'm going now," Mydei declares. Before anyone can object, he walks away from the group, down the path deeper into the city.

He goes quickly, without looking back, though the weight of their stares falls on him heavily. It's clear there's more to discuss—the fate of the Coreflame, what the fragment of Nikador had told Castorice and Stelle, and what comes next—but they won't need him for any of it. They'll be fine without him now that the battle is over.

Even so, departing like this feels vaguely shameful. It's an admission he's reached his limit. He knows they wouldn't look down on him for his injuries; they're all too *kind* for that. But he's so accustomed to leading the

Kremnoans that he avoids showing such weakness at all costs. He does the same now, walking away as briskly as he can, minimizing his limp to be as imperceptible as possible. Some Okhemans notice him, as they always do—neither his hair nor attire allow him to blend in—but judging by the reactions he earns, he must not look like he's died countless times today.

Normally, the long walk across the cityis entirely unremarkable to him. Today, however, Mydei finds himself reflecting on Okhema. Perhaps it's because his battered body feels every step of the journey; or maybe it's because he'd just visited Castrum Kremnos for the first time in twenty years. That fortress had never truly been his home, not like it was for most Kremnoans. His father had made sure of that. But it was still the closest thing he'd had to a place he'd belonged.

Despite—or perhaps because of—his history, he'd walked its ruined paths and silent halls with clear eyes. Castrum Kremnos had once been a monument to power and human determination, always ringing with the sounds of colossal engineering projects and relentless combat. The other city states had lived in fear of its might for eons. Yet in the end, it had been lost to crazed plots and reduced to rubble so quickly. The fortress is now merely an empty husk of its former glory.

Would his people, so long in exile, still desire to return there? Or is Kremnos truly gone?

Where Castrum Kremnos had been like a tomb, dead and decaying and haunted by the undying, Okhema is startlingly alive. The streets are crowded with people and dromases, the sounds of their voices and labor creating a bustling atmosphere. The towering marble buildings glow in the perpetual sunlight, and lush plants grow eagerly toward Kephale. It's all so mundane, yet so wondrous: an entire city living as though the black tide had never descended.

He'd hated it here when he arrived. The Okheman people seemed so passive and spoiled, their city among the cloudslavish and impractical. Mydei had led the exiled Kremnoan detachment here because it was the only place that might accept them, but their relationship has always been an uneasy one. There are still many Okhemans who see his people as

bloodthirsty savages who would betray their neighbors at the earliest opportunity.

The Kremnoans have their own lingering prejudices, believing Okhemans to be cowardly, dishonorable, weak, and foolish. In the face of the apocalypse, all they'd done was put their faith in Kephale and the Chrysos Heirs. To a child of Kremnos, such inaction in the face of an invasion was pathetic, idiotic, *infuriating* .

Yet Okhema stands untouched and untroubled, while Castrum Kremnos is a ruin and Nikador is dead.

It strikes Mydei that he's lived in Okhema for more years than all those he'd spent in Castrum Kremnos. These streets are now more familiar to him than those of his homeland, its people no longer strangers. Other Kremnoans wave and call out to him, but so do some Okhemans, and he has to put up his hand to wave some away.

Upon leaving Castrum Kremnos, he'd felt no loss or regrets. Rather, when he opened his eyes on this city, he'd felt himself relax ever-so-slightly. Could it be that after so long, he's unwittingly come to feel at peace here?

By the time he arrives at the Marmoreal Palace, Mydei's reserve of energy has drained to the final dregs. He's no longer able to completely hide his limp, his injured knee too painful and wrecked from pushing himself. Fortunately, he knows the back passages of this place well. Once he slips into the darker, hidden halls, he can slow his pace and hobble without worrying about being spotted. A warrior prince in such a state would likely send a panic through not only the Okhemans, but also his own people. He'd rather avoid causing such a stir.

His rooms are at the top floor of the baths, high above the streets. Aglaea had offered the suite to him years ago, on account of him being a Chrysos heir. It feels a bit too much like charity for his liking, but his advisor Krateros had begged him to accept it. The older man had a point: this space is far more befitting a crown prince than the massively overpriced apartments he'd been renting in the city before. The role of deserter prince living in exile paid far less than Okhemans assumed. Even if he'd been

dishonorable enough to make off with the treasures of Castrum Kremnos, it wouldn't have made much difference: his father had already squandered most of their fortune on his schemes. However, this meant nothing in the eternal holy city. Most landlords took a look at Mydei and proclaimed that their vacancies had recently become occupied. The only ones that would rent to him were those who quoted clearly extortionate rates.

At last, Mydei slips into his rooms unnoticed. After living in them for years, they've started to feel like they're his, despite their Okheman aesthetics. He's not sure he'll ever get used to the wholly unnecessary luxuries: delicate and lustrous fabrics, the window made of colored glass in intricate patterns, the ornate mosaic tub, and tables heaped with fresh fruits and wine. And of course there is the eternal sun, ever bright and unchanging.

Once, that sun had kept him awake at all hours, though he'd been too stubborn to admit it. Now, however, he is used to its presence. Besides, he's far too exhausted for the light to bother him. Mydei strips out of his filthy clothes and sinks into the hot water of his private bath. The heat immediately relaxes his muscles and helps ease his excruciating pain. He scrubs off the lingering blood and muck that he had been unable to remove back at Castrum Kremnos. Before long, he feels his eyelids slide shut, and slips into an irresistible sleep.

A loud knock rouses him from his rest some time later.

Mydei feels like he's been trampled by an entire group of dromases, repeatedly. His whole body aches, muscles and bones and skin alike all protesting the stress he'd put them through.

There's another knock, then someone shouting, "Mydei? Are you alright?"

He recognizes that voice. With a groan, he realizes that Phainon is probably attracting all sorts of unwanted attention with his yelling. Mydei shifts his body into a more upright position and calls out, "Come in."

A thick mane of silver hair pokes into the room first, as though he's checking for a trap. Phainon wears a surprised expression as he enters and

lets the heavy doors close behind him. “I was starting to doubt that you would invite me in.”

Mydei crosses his arms. “You were making a scene out there.”

“Well, I wouldn’t have had to yell if you’d just answered me!” Despite his protest, Phainon’s lips turn up to a sunny smile.

It makes Mydei roll his eyes. How is the other man so happy and energetic after everything? “I was sleeping, Deliverer.”

That makes Phainon squint. “But you’re in the bath.” When Mydei doesn’t reply, he continues, “You can’t just sleep in the bath! What if you… I don’t know, fall over?”

“Are you worried I’m going to drown and die?”

“Okay, fair enough.” Phainon says.

His guest falls quiet after that. It’s somewhat unsettling—in his experience, Phainon never shuts up—so Mydei decides to break the awkward silence. “Is there some reason you’re here?”

Phainon gives him a look, like he thinks Mydei might be an idiot. “I wanted to make sure my friend is doing okay, obviously.”

“We’re not friends.”

The second he says it, Mydei regrets his words. He hadn’t meant for them to sound so… harsh.

“Do you really have to treat me like an enemy? Even after today?”

Phainon’s face seems transformed from his usual cheer, and his voice sounds *hurt*. Even from this distance, the dark circles under his eyes and his grim expression make him look thoroughly exhausted. While he hadn’t fought Nikador for quite as long, Phainon had been running himself ragged, too.

Unbidden, Mydei remembers the relief he'd felt when Phainon had arrived and interrupted his unending duel with Nikador. If the other man hadn't arrived, he's not sure he would've emerged from that conflict with his sanity intact.

Apologies have never been his strong suit, though. Instead, Mydei says, "You don't need to stand over there. You can join me."

Phainon raises his eyebrows in surprise, yet he doesn't say anything as he strips out of his clothing and clambers into the pool. He chooses a spot next to Mydei, on one of the ledges that double as steps and seats. It's about halfway down the bath, deep enough to cover him to the waist. The position leaves Phainon close enough to touch, but not in his personal space. Mydei doesn't mind it too much.

As Phainon slides into the water, he hisses behind clenched teeth. "Gods, the water's hot."

"It's best for wounds and sore muscles at this temperature."

"Of course. You're not like the Okhemans who treat the baths as a social occasion."

Mydei scoffs at that.

Phainon smiles in response. "I'm glad to see you're acting a bit more like your normal self. When Dan Heng and I arrived during your fight with Nikador, you seemed… off." There's a moment of hesitation before he continues. "It was like you didn't even recognize your own name."

"That's because I didn't." The other man's face transforms, looking far too much like he *pities* him. "Don't give me that look. It doesn't matter."

That seems to make Phainon even more outraged. "What do you mean by that?!"

"Well, Deliverer, I'm fine now. And in any case, my mission was to defeat Nikador. Nothing else mattered—not even knowing my own name."

“Gods!” Phainon exclaims, putting his head in his hands. “I’m going to be nice and ignore the part where I can’t know you’re doing better if you won’t *tell* me. But I’m not going to overlook the rest of it! You realize that you do matter, right? And not just because you can take on a Titan single-handed.” He lets out an excessively dramatic sigh. “ And people say *I’m* reckless with my own life! I wonder how they'd react if they met you.”

Mydei isn’t sure how to respond to most of what Phainon’s said. He feels overly warm, but does his best to ignore the uncomfortable feeling. “That's different, idiot. I can't die anyway.”

“Not for lack of trying,” Phainon mutters. “In any case, your immortality doesn't mean you can't suffer, does it?”

How can Mydei respond to that? Of course he still feels; of course he can still be injured. What point is there in dwelling on the obvious? So he doesn’t say anything.

Phainon is staring at him intently, clearly expecting a reply. When he doesn’t get one, he starts talking again. “I was there, remember? Dan Heng was, too. It was clear that you were barely hanging on. As we ran up, we heard these noises like… like some kind of injured, feral animal. Imagine our shock to find out it was *you* making those sounds. I don’t think I’ve ever seen someone experiencing that kind of torturous physical pain before. And then you wouldn’t even respond to your name…”

“Well, they call it a curse of immortality for a reason.”

“Why are you so opposed to accepting my concern for you?” Phainon looks frustrated and tired and maybe a bit like he wants to punch him. “You’re acting like nothing happened, or that I’m foolish to worry about it. How many times did you *die,* Mydei? Don't you think that might've had an effect on you?”

Mydei’s shoulders are starting to ache from crossing them, so he uncrosses them and forces the muscles to relax. He wishes that he could just kick Phainon out right now and go to sleep. The only thing stopping him is the obvious hurt already on the other man’s face. Tomorrow, Phainon will face

the trial of the Coreflame, and Mydei doesn’t want to spit on him before that.

Grudgingly, he tells Phainon a bit of what the fight was like. “I didn't keep track of how many times I nearly died. I don't know how long I fought, or how many times I fell. The battle seemed very long to me, much longer than it truly was.”

“I can't imagine. Coming close to death so many times… it must have been excruciating.”

“Not really. I was only doing my duty.”

“Can you stop that?” It’s the first time he’s ever heard Phainon direct such anger at him. “Why do you insist on making light of what you went through —what we both went through? You know that you’re not the only one who fought Nikador, right?

“I’m also a warrior.” Phainon continues. “This was hardly my first fight. But I’ve never encountered anything like that before. A single battle against one undying foe, with no chance to regroup or catch my breath… trying to keep going as my stamina slowly depleted, hoping that my friends would be able to save the day... it wasn’t just any fight.”

Mydei feels his stomach clench. It’s rare that he regrets his blunt words, yet Phainon seems to be an exception.“I’m not trying to insult your efforts. I know that you sacrificed and suffered. The fight was... far from ordinary.” He meets Phainon’s gaze again. “But I’m not like you, Deliverer. I’m no good at talking, only fighting.”

Next to him, Phainon relaxes slightly at the unstated apology. “You’re not half-bad at talking when you try. Your problem is that you won’t let anyone express even a hint of concern for you.”

“I just don’t know what you want from me. Kremnoans don’t sit around complaining about how hard and miserable the battle was.”

“Yeah, and we just saw what a well-adjusted bunch you all were! Maybe you should consider trying something new, like actually talking about your emotions.”

To his surprise, Mydei bursts into laughter at the absurd suggestion. “I’m sure my soldiers will start any day now.” His amusement fades a bit as he considers. “ You’re not wrong, though—we don’t need what happened at Castrum Kremnos to occur again. Maybe your idea would benefit them.”

That lightens the mood between them considerably. Phainon smiles wider than he has since the joined the bath. “Oh, have I finally made the brusque crown prince see the value of sharing his thoughts and feelings with his friends?”

Mydei grimaces. “Hmph. I’ll let you recommend this… emotional support concept to my advisors yourself.”

An ironic laugh bubbles up from Phainon. “You might be on your own there. I imagine they'd respond as well to that suggestion coming from me, as our leader would to open dissent.”

“Well, Kremnoans aren’t going to change quickly. If nothing else, we are determined.”

“Ha! That’s one word for it. I prefer ‘unbelievably stubborn.’”

Mydei makes a “hmph” noise.

“Exactly like that!” Phainon laughs.

In the comfortable quiet that follows, Mydei stretches out his legs. They accidentally knock against Phainon’s, but it’s a pleasant kind of companionship between comrades. Perhaps that’s what they are now, after fighting Nikador side-by-side.

Unsurprisingly, Phainon is the one to break the silence. “Can I ask you something?”

“Will you stop talking if I say no?” Mydei jokes. “I wasn’t aware that anyone could shut you up.”

Phainon takes that for the permission it is. “That’s just part of my charm. Anyway, I’m curious. You told me that you agreed with the values of Strife.”

He nods. “Well, I am Kremnoan.”

“So what?”

Mydei gives him a disdainful look. “I am the crown prince of Castrum Kremnos, a follower of Nikador. Of course I follow the path of Strife.”

“Former follower,” Phainon corrects. “You helped destroy Nikador. Surely that means you don’t agree with them?”

“Not necessarily.”

Phainon shakes his head. “I really don’t understand. You killed your own god. You murdered your own father. You left your city behind. And yet you insist that you believe in everything they stood for… why?”

The words stir up a churning hollow roar in Mydei. He hadn’t expected Phainon to talk about his past like that. For a moment, he’s tempted to strike back by bringing up Phainon’s own destroyed homeland. It would inevitably make him furious, though, and as irritated as he is, he doesn’t *really* want to upset Phainon. Mydei’s simply too exhausted right now to want to deal with this.

“Oh, fuck.” Phainon must notice his reaction. “I shouldn’t have said any of that. I’m sorry, Mydei.”

“It’s fine.”

“No, I really crossed the line. I’m supposed to be helping you out, not…”

“Not reminding me of my sins?”

Phainon’s hand reaches for him. “Myd-”

He yanks his body to the side and crosses his arms, cutting the other man off. “You can just say it. Patricide. Desertion. Do you think I haven’t heard people say those words a thousand times?” He gestures at his torso, with its broad muscles and vivid tattoos on display to all. Mydei’s long gotten used to the constant gawking, and the people flinching away when he returns their stares coldly. “Every time I go out, I hear the whispers—the rumors about me, about my people. I’m certain that they’ll add deicide to my list of crimes when they learn about Nikador’s fall.”

“I-” Phainon’s hand drops in the water with a muted splash. “I’m sorry.”

Mydei thinks that maybe he is free of the conversation, but he underestimates Phainon’s persistence. “I still cannot understand, though. Why fight Nikador or your father if you share their beliefs? I… well, I never would’ve fought against Aedes Elysiae.”

The mention of Phainon’s homeland makes Mydei relax his guard just a bit. Perhaps the question isn’t an attack; maybe it’s personal.

“Things are different in Castrum Kremnos. We are warriors. Killing can be a sign of respect.”

“That’s absurd.”

“It’s the truth,” Mydei says. “Every prince kills the king—his father—before he can succeed him to rule Kremnos. It ensures we are always led by the strongest warrior, while the loser falls. It’s a time-honored rite.”

“Even if that’s true, you never took the throne, right? You never finished the ascension ritual.”

Mydei shifts slightly. “It’s complicated.”

“I know you think I’m just some naive idiot that can’t understand your people’s ways. And perhaps I am,” Phainon flashes a small, wry smile at

him. “But it seems to me that at every stage, you expressed your disagreement with Nikador’s philosophy.”

“How so?”

“You left the city because you saw your people heading down a dark path. You killed your father, but refused to wear the crown that was rightfully yours. Instead of staying and shaping Castrum Kremnos to your will, you left the city behind and let it fall into ruin.”

“What are you trying to say, Deliverer?” Mydei asks, voice harsh. “That I’m a traitor to my people? That I destroyed our civilization?”

“Not at all,” Phainon says. His blue eyes blaze fiercely. “I think you’re a leader, and you’ve led the Kremnoans away from the false path of Strife.”

“Hmph, of course that’s what you would think.”

“Tell me, Mydei,” Phainon says, staring so intensely that Mydei can’t look away. “If you believe that war is always justified, not for any cause but merely for the pursuit of glory—if that is true, then why did you stop Nikador from invading Okhema?”

Mydei stiffens. “Nikador was corrupted and acting without honor. Stopping his cowardly plan is entirely befitting a follower of strife.”

“But you fought to defend Okhema in the past, long before you knew about any of that. Why not just let the Titankin overrun the city?”

“I made a promise to Aglaea, both as a Chrysos heir and to secure a place for the Kremnoan detachment that followed me.”

Phainon is not deterred. “And what if you hadn’t made any promises? What if you had seen the Titankin coming and had to choose how to act, without other concerns? Would you have joined them and fought on the side of Strife, waging war on Okhema?”

Finally, Mydei is able to look away from the other man, his gaze moving to the open doorway leading to his private balcony. Through it, he can just

glimpse the once-lovely landscape, now in ruins. The towns near Okhema were once peaceful. They thrived under Kephale's protection. Gradually, though, the relentless attacks from Castrum Kremnos destroyed every place the black tide had swallowed. Now, only the city of Okhema itself, bathed in perpetual light, remains safe.

He's fought in those remnants of ravaged towns and cities countless times. The ruined temples, the abandoned homes, the cowering survivors… they fill him with disgust, yes, but also something far more uncomfortable—pity.

"No, I wouldn't," Mydei says quietly. "Okhema is the last city. There is no honor in its destruction. At their best, Nikador was a protector."

"I'm sorry, I shouldn't have pushed you." Phainon says. "It's… probably not my place. I just don't believe that you actually support the things we saw in Castrum Kremnos. You're not a bad guy."

"Hmm, tell that to the people of Okhema."

Phainon shoves him lightly. "Don't you realize that a ton of people in this city love you?"

Mydei scoffs. "Sure they do. That's why I get dirty looks whenever I go out."

"I'm not saying *everyone* loves you! But you have a lot of fans! That dessert shop wouldn't have gotten you to advertise their golden honeycakes if you were only despised."

"It's no concern of mine how businesses choose to waste their money."

"Ha! You made that shop huge amounts of sales! Honeycakes are one of the most popular foods these days, all thanks to your popularity."

Mydei shifts uncomfortably. "That's hard to imagine."

Phainon sighs loudly. "Ugh, you're so stubborn. And you're surprisingly bad at understanding how others see you."

“And you aren’t?” Mydei immediately cringes after he speaks. It comes across as horribly childish and defensive.

“You think so?” Phainon asks, once again giving a sardonic smile. “Those who don’t know me well see me as a hero, sure. Yet it seems to me that my doubts and anxieties are constantly on display for anyone to see if they look.” He sighs and hangs his head. “But perhaps you’re right. I’m still a liar, aren’t I? Somehow, I am convinced I can delude others… and even myself.”

Mydei knocks his arm against Phainon’s. “Come off it. You’re thinking too much. It doesn’t suit a hero like you.”

Phainon looks up and laughs. It’s small and a bit fragile, but Mydei will take it. “Are you saying I’m an idiot who shouldn’t try to think too hard?”

“Yes, exactly. You’re the type that ought to be swinging his blade valiantly, not the thinking type.”

“You’re probably right. I get stuck thinking about these things, but it feels like I always make the wrong decision anyway.”

For some reason, seeing Phainon like this makes Mydei feel like he should say something nice. He has never been the sort to care overly much about other people’s emotions or opinions; he simply does what he thinks is best, regardless of whether or not others will agree with it. But he dislikes seeing Phainon sad. The other man ought to be smiling and speaking nonsense.

“Come on, Deliverer, this kind of talk doesn’t suit you. I thought you came here to pester me into talking about the fight with Nikador.”

Phainon shakes his head. “I’m here to check on you and help you heal. And I’m doing a terrible job.”

Well, he’s certainly gotten a bit distracted, but Mydei isn’t going to point that out. “Most of the surface wounds have already closed. Now it’s just a matter of healing bones and muscles. I should be fine in a few days at most.”

“Gods, I envy you for that.” Phainon gripes. “Anyway, maybe I can still help you. Would you like a massage?”

Had Phainon asked earlier, he’d probably have said no, more out of reflex than any particular aversion. Now, though, Mydei would feel bad refusing the offer. His bath partner looks so earnest, like it would genuinely make him sad to be turned down.

“...Sure.”

That makes Phainon smile more brightly. It stirs something in Mydei, something he’s not really interested in examining. Instead, he reaches over to the nearby tray where he keeps his bathing essentials. “Here’s the massage oil.”

“Thanks.” Phainon accepts the jar, then directs him to turn slightly. “This way, I can rub your back first.”

Normally, Mydei gets massages from one of the professionals employed in the Marmoreal Palace. In contrast, Phainon’s hands are heavily calloused, as a warrior’s should be. The sensation of them against his back is unexpected, yet pleasant. The oil eliminates some of the roughness, but not all of it. The strength and texture of those digits feels good against his skin.

“You’re stiff as a board,” Phainon chastises. “Try to relax.”

It’s a bit harder when Phainon is the one rubbing him. It feels far more personal like this, the both of them in his private bath, and no official roles dictating their interaction.

Even so, as Phainon massages his back, Mydei’s body slowly relaxes. Phainon is surprisingly talented—perhaps not so surprising, considering that he seems to succeed at anything he dedicates himself to.

Before long, Mydei realizes he’s making little noises involuntarily. He lets out slight sounds of discomfort when Phainon digs too deep into a wound. Phainon reacts immediately, lessening the pressure and avoiding the most sensitive spots.

More embarrassingly, Mydei sometimes makes noises when something feels particularly good. Phainon is responsive to those, too, spending more time rubbing the area and adjusting the force to elicit an even stronger reaction.

Massages are a common part of life, something Mydei's long since become accustomed to receiving. Yet now that Phainon is the one touching him, he feels bizarrely abashed, especially about the sounds he's making.

He's nearly managed to ignore the awkwardness when Phainon speaks again, this time while massaging his bicep. "Has anyone ever told you that you're surprisingly cute?"

"*Cute*?!" Mydei shakes his head. "No, never. I assume you're the only one with that kind of death wish."

"I'm just saying, when you're not killing monsters, you're kind of cute. You're like a great, big felys from the stories."

"Deliverer…" Mydei says menacingly. "Are you truly comparing me to some tiny, adorable domesticated beast? Think *very* carefully before you respond."

Phainon sighs. "Fine, you're like a majestic lion. Is that better?"

"...It is acceptable."

Even though Mydei can't see his face, he's *certain* that Phainon is smiling at his expense.

"Don't mock me," he says.

The hands at his back pause briefly. "I promise I would never." As Phainon resumes his massage, he changes the subject. "It's honestly unfair how quickly you heal. Aside from the bruises, there's no sign of the fight on you."

"There are some advantages to my curse," Mydei says simply.

“Truly,” Phainon replies. “Can you turn to me? I’m going to massage your legs next.”

The pool is shallow enough that it’s easy to adjust his lower leg to be slightly above the water. The angle is slightly more awkward, though, now that they are facing each other again.

At first, Mydei studies the other man. Phainon’s floppy silver hair is much messier than usual, though it still looks charmingly ruffled. The position of his head and his long eyelashes mostly obscure the startling blue of his eyes. Even at this angle, though, his face is easy to observe. He wears a gentle but focused expression, with his lips turned in a small smile as he works. He seems content.

Then, there’s the long, pale line of Phainon’s neck to his bare chest, only interrupted by the black choker he always seems to have on. When he’d stripped, he hadn’t removed it, leaving Mydei to wonder if it holds some kind of deeper significance. Perhaps he’d just forgotten it? Mydei is curious, but it does look nice against his milky flesh, and draws even more attention to the yellow sunburst on his neck. It looks a bit like a collar this way, as though Phainon is some sort of pet.

If anyone is cute, it’s certainly not *Mydei*. How ridiculous of Phainon of all people to say that to him. Though he’s undoubtedly a warrior, Phainon possesses a certain softness that is far more felys-like. Mydei has seen how Okhemans react to the hero, too, and can tell they share his assessment.

Mydei’s tempted to say this, but he’s sure that the other man would argue back. Perhaps he’ll wait for another day to tease him. As much as he enjoys riling Phainon up, they’ve dealt with enough today already.

Besides, he’s already distracted enough by the massage.

As Phainon had rubbed his way up Mydei’s legs, he’d gradually moved closer. Their bodies are now touching far more than before, Mydei’s entire lower leg pressed against his companion.

“We should rearrange ourselves,” Phainon says. “I can’t reach much from this far away.”

Mydei nods. “That seems reasonable. Do you want me to move?”

“You’re fine where you are. Can you just part your legs a bit more?”

The request doesn’t seem odd to Mydei, so he adjusts his position and spreads his legs even further apart. He’s not entirely sure where he expects Phainon to move. However, he’s *definitely not* expecting what happens: Phainon clambers forward, to the place right between his legs, and kneels on the step below him.

“How is this position?” Phainon asks.

Fuck. Mydei has no idea how to respond. How do you tell a man that he’s kneeling between your spread thighs and that there are very few innocent explanations for such a thing? “I-” Mydei coughs, trying to hide how raspy and low his voice sounds. “It’s fine.”

Phainon nods. “Good. I can massage you much more easily this way.”

With that, Phainon reaches out and begins rubbing Mydei’s thigh.

The moan he lets out is by far the most embarrassing one so far. This time, Mydei is uncomfortably aware of how similar it sounds to a sexual one. Fortunately, Phainon doesn’t seem to notice. Just how innocent is that man, anyway?

While Phainon may be pure of lascivious intentions, Mydei is finding that he is not. The massage feels excellent, as before, but also incredibly intimate. Even the professional masseurs rarely touch his thighs like this. His skin is sensitive here, and every touch makes his nerves buzz with pleasure.

And then there’s Phainon. From this new position, Mydei finds it hard to look away from him. Phainon is deeper in the pool now, so the water comes up almost to his pectoral muscles. It draws attention to how shapely his

chest is—a chest that's usually hidden behind armor and layers of fabric, unlike Mydei's own—and to the delicate pink nipples that poke up from it.

He has to swallow the next noise he makes when Phainon digs in particularly deep to a sensitive spot. Though he wants to deny it, Mydei is growing hard, and rapidly.

"Maybe we should stop here," he says. Even to his own ears, his voice sounds a bit odd.

Phainon frowns. "I haven't finished massaging your legs yet," he argues, his eyes meeting Mydei's in challenge.He keeps rubbing. "It shouldn't take too much longer."

"It's unnecessary," Mydei says. He can't look away from Phainon. Has the man always been this attractive? Phainon's face is flushed faintly pink from the heat, and his lips are surprisingly full.

"I might as well finish, though." Phainon keeps his eyes locked with Mydei's as he moves his hand even higher, pressing his thumb into Mydei's inner thigh. Just a bit higher and the man would be brushing against his balls.

The proximity to his cock sends another wave of arousal through Mydei. He's rapidly approaching full hardness. "Deliverer, I…"

A smile spreads across Phainon's lips. It's wicked, knowing. "Is this what has you worried?" He asks, and gestures toward Mydei's lap.

To Mydei's horror, his dick is so hard that it's bobbing above the surface of the water, red and throbbing and unmistakable. His face flushes immediately, and he reaches for a towel he can use to cover himself. Unfortunately, there's nothing at hand.

"It's fine, De. It doesn't bother me."

"…You!" Mydei makes a weak attempt to move his body back, but Phainon's hands massaging him are strong enough to keep him in place.

“Were you doing this on purpose, to seduce me?”

That same amused smile greets him. “I was simply giving you a massage. I’m not to blame for your reaction just because I sat between your legs.”

Is this the punishment Mydei had earned by killing his god? Even now, he grows more aroused with every touch. “Well, are you going to stop the massage?”

“I mean… I *could*,” Phainon says, voice low and considering. “I could also help you take care of your problem.”

It’s a horrible idea. They can hardly even stand each other’s presence. Right now, Mydei is particularly inclined to throttle Phainon. And yet.. does he really want to turn down an attractive man offering to get him off? It’s been far, far too long since someone proposed this. As a Kremnoan, the Okhemans avoid him, while his status as crown prince means that most of his own people see him only as a leader, not a human with sexual urges.

He crosses his arms. “Fine. This is your fault, anyway. You should fix it.”

Phainon’s smile is charmingly crooked as he takes his hands off Mydei’s legs. “If you say so, prince. Now, I need you to move up to the next ledge.”

“Hmph, fine.” Mydei moves back and up to the higher step, which brings his lap fully out of the water. His cock stands proudly, urgently demanding attention.

Once again, Phainon moves closer. This time, however, he keeps going until he’s fully between Mydei’s upper thighs, resting one hand on his hip and bringing the other one to his dick. Then, he leans forward quickly and swallows the tip.

“Fuck,” Mydei groans. He’s been expecting a hand job, not for Phainon to suck him off. Not that he’s complaining, of course. Phainon’s mouth is hot and wet and *perfect*.

Phainon’s hand strokes along his length as his tongue laves against the cock head. Just as the targeted sensation is becoming too much, he backs off, swallowing more of the shaft. Mydei is torn between wanting to orgasm instantly and wanting for the sensation to last forever.

His hands reach forward and tangle into Phainon’s silver hair. Now that he’s touching Phainon, Mydei realizes how much he’d wanted this—to feel his soft locks and see the way his eyes widen slightly at each gentle tug.

In response, Phainon relaxes his jaw and presses his head forward, taking in more of Mydei's substantial length. It’s rare that someone is able to swallow him like this. How much practice has Phainon had, exactly? He's almost jealous.

It feels unbelievably good—almost too good, the way things are going. Mydei still has his pride, and he suspects that if he comes this quickly, Phainon won’t let him forget it.

There’s only one thing to do. “Who knew that all this time, while you wouldn't shut up, you could've been putting your mouth to far better use like this?” Mydei says.

As expected, Phainon makes an offended noise and immediately slides his mouth off of Mydei’s cock. With this improved angle, Mydei can see that his eyes are glossy from the blow job. The sight makes his dick throb. He’d never imagined any of this happening, but even if he had, there’s no way he would’ve been able to guess how handsome and beautiful Phainon looks like this.

“Hey! Don’t insult the one giving you an amazing blow job, you asshole! Hasn’t anyone ever taught you to be nicer to someone who has his teeth that close to your dick?” Thankfully, Phainon doesn’t look like he’s actually upset.

“I’m not insulting you,” Mydei smiles, happy he got his desired outcome. “I’m complimenting your skills. I simply prefer when you put your mouth to use this way. You know I’m not one for talking.”

Phainon rolls his eyes. “Typical.” There’s a playful gleam in his gaze. “I see how it is. Halfway through a single blow job, and you already only want to use me for sex.”

“That’s right,” Mydei agrees. He slips two fingers into Phainon’s mouth, eliciting a gasp from him. “I want to see if you can take all of me, Deliverer.” With his fingers, he presses against Phainon’s tongue, enjoying the way he lets his mouth be manipulated so easily. Mydei then slides in his thumb, caressing the roof of his mouth with it to gently pry his lips open. A trail of saliva falls from between Phainon’s parted lips lasciviously before Mydei withdraws his hand.

“Gods,” Phainon says. By now, his voice sounds unmistakably aroused, too. “You truly are a menace.”

Mydei almost complains about the irony of *Phainon* of all people saying that, but he’s stopped when Phainon slides back down and immediately deep throats him. He makes a strangled noise that definitely doesn’t sound like a squeal as he watches that silver head rapidly descend and take in every inch of his considerable length.

“Fuck,” he groans, almost crazy at the sensation of Phainon’s nose in his pubic hair. No one has ever managed to do that before. He’s not sure anyone had been daring enough to even try.

Once again, Mydei’s fingers curl into Phainon’s hair, but this time he tugs more roughly. The noise that Phainon makes in response encourages him. Mydei pulls again, and Phainon eagerly rocks forward, mouth squeezing every inch of him as he slurps away obscenely. It pushes him even closer to the brink of orgasm.

Starting slowly at first, Mydei pulls out slightly, then fucks into Phainon’s throat. Phainon meets his every move, his throat tight and welcoming. Tension spreads through Mydei’s body as he thrusts into Phainon’s willing mouth faster and faster. It’s rough and intense, but not cruel. Phainon moans on his cock, his broken, desperate noises telling Mydei that he’s not the only one enjoying this.

Gods, he’s so close. Mydei’s body feels so tight with arousal that he’s going to burst at any moment. Still, he wants to make this last, to enjoy every second of this intense blow job.

Suddenly, Phainon’s fingers tease his balls and the skin behind them.

“Phainon,” Mydei shouts,and comes harder than he ever has in his life. He shoots down Phainon’s throat, relishing the feeling of that hot flesh massaging him through his peak. As he’s still coming, Phainon slides off his cock, and gets hit in the face with the last few spurts of cum. Perhaps it was intentional; Phainon isn’t complaining, in any case. The streaks of white crossing Phainon’s flushed, dewy skin are dazzlingly hot. Mydei wishes he could take a photo of it to preserve it for eternity. The best he can do is sear the image of it into his memory: Phainon, kneeling and naked, cum in his eyelashes and spit dripping from his gaping mouth.

“Fuck,” Mydei says again as he slumps backward as though boneless. He feels stupid, unable to communicate anything worth saying. “That was amazing.”

“Well, I’m a hero of many talents,” Phainon jokes. He wipes away the saliva and cum dripping from his lips and moves over to the steps by Mydei. As Phainon lifts his body up, his cock is on display. It's a very similar size to Mydei's, though perhaps slightly longer and more slender, and it’s fully erect and dark with arousal.

“Do you need help with that?” Mydei asks, gesturing toward his lap.

Phainon flushes a bit. “You don’t have to. I came here to help you out while you’re healing, remember?”

“I feel fine. Besides, it would be rude not to reciprocate.”

“Ha, well in that case I’d be a fool to say no,” Phainon laughs. “I’d be honored if you would get me off, Prince Mydei.”

Mydei pulls a face. “Shut up.”

Despite his words, he moves toward Phainon, taking in the view as the other man moves his legs apart. Mydei approaches Phainon's cock slowly. It's truly strange to see Phainon like this, naked and undeniably aroused, his legs spread wide.

But is it really so odd?

All at once, Mydei realizes that he's always had an unfavorable view of Phainon in his mind, one he's now finding was never fair or true. Maybe it's because the people of Okhema had always seemed to love Phainon so easily, and so he'd considered Phainon to be the stereotype of a hero: annoyingly and unfailingly honorable, a bit naive and even stupid, and so generically good and pure that he'd never thought about sex before. Today, Phainon is proving those assumptions wrong. Mydei had only been right about the honor.

There's no point dwelling on such things for now, however. Mydei has a simple task to accomplish: get Phainon off.

It would be much easier to use some of the massage oil and stroke Phainon off to completion. With the way that Phainon's cock throbs, and the dewy liquid forming at its head like a pearl, Mydei suspects it wouldn't even take very long. There’s also the small detail that he’s not particularly experienced at sucking cock. Even fewer Kremnoans feel it is proper for their prince to serve them sexually, so he’s rarely had the opportunity to give blow jobs. He’s certain he's never had such a large dick in his mouth before. However, he's not one to be intimidated by a challenge, and definitely not one to back down.

As if he can read Mydei's thoughts, Phainon says, "Are you just going to stare at it?" He sounds good-natured about it, but Mydei still bristles somewhat.

"Obviously not."

He takes a steady breath and then Mydei leans the rest of the way forward, bringing his mouth to Phainon's cock and swallowing a third of it at once.

Immediately, he regrets his choices.

Mydei has only sucked someone off a few times in his life, and it's been so long that he forgot how intense it feels to have a mouth full of dick. Aside from the fullness, there are teeth to worry about, and what to do with his tongue. The taste of pre-cum is distracting, too, strangely salty and bitter, and a bit viscous. He feels like he’s plunged head-first into a battle carrying a weapon he barely knows how to wield.

"Mmm, that feels good, De," Phainon says. Mydei feels a soft touch on his head, then a hand stroking his hair gently.

Part of him wants to argue with Phainon, tell him that the crown prince of Kremnos of all people doesn't require this kind of *soft* treatment. Another part of him suspects he just wants an excuse to get the cock out of his mouth. Mydei decides to focus on the task at hand. Besides, the fingers combing through his hair feel shockingly good.

After a minute of relaxing his jaw, Mydei's mouth feels slightly more comfortable. He begins to coordinate his movements, though not very smoothly at first. With his tongue, he rubs along Phainon’s shaft, while his lips and mouth hollow out to suck most effectively. Once he feels he's mastered those basic motions, Mydei starts to slowly move his head up and down Phainon's length.

"Oh, De, that's incredible. It feels amazing," Phainon praises him with a husky voice.

Of course Phainon is the type to never shut up during sex—at least, as long as his mouth's unoccupied. As much as Mydei wants to hate it, though, he actually sort of likes Phainon's chatter right now. The man’s incessant talking and moaning makes it easier to hear when he’s doing something right with his mouth.

"Can you take a bit more of me?" Phainon asks, then rocks very gently into Mydei’s mouth. "I want to feel my cock in your throat."

Those words make Mydei blush furiously. Who could’ve guessed that Phainon, the friendly hero of the people,would be capable of saying such shameless things?

He slides down Phainon's dick slowly, until the head of it brushes against his sensitive throat. Immediately, Mydei gags, his throat muscles convulsing against the intrusion. For a second, he thinks he's going to vomit.

The wanton moan that Phainon lets out helps make his discomfort feel more worthwhile, at least. "Gods, *yes*, just like that. You're doing so good."

Mydei forces himself to keep sucking Phainon’s cock, even though his throat protests several times. The muscles gradually start to relax around the dick a bit, which he takes as a sign to push himself more. Very cautiously, he moves his mouth down Phainon's erection, until the cock head slides fully down his throat.

"De, fuck. That's perfect. You’re perfect." Phainon tugs on Mydei's hair, and Mydei can't help but moan around the cock at the sensation. Phainon's gaze on him feels unbelievably intense and hot. "Who would believe that the crown prince of Kremnos would have such a perfect mouth for fucking?"

Before he can object to this description, Phainon gently thrusts in then out of Mydei's mouth. Even at this slow pace, Mydei is immediately overwhelmed by it. His throat reflexively tries to shut around the cock pressing ever-deeper, and his eyes water. Despite his best efforts, he struggles to keep track of all the sensations and parts of his body.

He might not even have realized that his lips fell a bit slack if it weren't for Phainon. The other man presses his thumb to the opening of Mydei's lips, which have apparently gaped open.Then Phainon slides the pad of the finger into Mydei's mouth, too. It feels vaguely demeaning, the way that Phainon acts without asking permission, but Mydei can't deny the effect that it hason him. Already, his own cock—which has been gradually recovering from his earlier orgasm—is half hard and growing.

"Gods, you really are cute," Phainon says. "And so hot. We should've been doing this already."

Mydei nods, and Phainon smiles.

"I think with more practice, you could learn to take all of me. You'd look good with my whole cock inside you."

Fuck, Mydei can hardly stand all this ridiculous talk. He doesn't need that thought in his head right now to distract him from his goal.

With his face blazing from arousal and embarrassment, Mydei redoubles his efforts. He sucks harder, taking in as much of Phainon as he can. Though he thinks he's managed an impressive amount, his lips are still inches from the base of Phainon's dick. There's no way he's going to be able to handle the entire length today.

Instead,Mydei wraps his hand around the neglected part of the shaft and starts jerking it off, matching the rhythm of Phainon's hips. Phainon withdraws his finger from Mydei's mouth, choosing to return that hand to Mydei's head to guide him as he deepens his thrusts.

By now, even Phainon is having trouble speaking, though he's louder than ever. He moans shamelessly, punctuating his noises of pleasure with exclamations and Mydei's name. And of course, he keeps praising Mydei. "You're so good, Prince," Phainon manages, then devolves into groans.

Mydei can hardly keep up. He tries to at least keep his mouth shut tight, but the blow job is increasingly sloppy and frantic. His face feels wet with his spit, and his mouth is starting to feel sore from all this thrusting. Phainon bucks into him erratically, his earlier rhythm totally gone.

"De, I'm gonna—!" With a final thrust, Phainon tenses and yells out his orgasm.

Hot seed hits Mydei's throat, and suddenly he really *is* choking. Frantically, Mydei pulls off of Phainon's cock so he can cough up what went down his windpipe. It means he catches most of Phainon's cum on his face and chest

and even hair. He’s sure that he looks ridiculous, though anything is better than choking on all that cum.

Phainon looks up and sees him coughing. "Shit, Mydei, I’m sorry. That felt so good that I didn't have time to think." Mydei isn't an idiot, though;he sees the way that Phainon subtly licks his lips at the sight.

"Hmph, as though you aren't glad that I’m covered in your mess."

Phainon laughs and smiles widely. "Sure, I admit it. You look absolutely stunning this way. But next time, I should probably pull out intentionally, since I don’t want to hurt you."

“It’s not like you can break me that easily, Deliverer,” Mydei says, crossing his arms, and turning his head to the side. Phainon’s confident assertion that there will be a next time makes Mydei flush harder.

He wipes some of the most distracting cum off himself and evaluates. After blowing Phainon, he's hard again, and eager to come a second time. As he drinks in the sight of Phainon, the man’s body completely naked aside from his choker, Mydei is possessed by the desire to fuck him. There's oil nearby, and he's still just a few inches from Phainon's hole. It would be so easy to slip inside and fuck him until he’s satisfied.

But as he studies Phainon's face and looks at his full lips, Mydei realizes he can't, not now. They had exchanged casual blow jobs, nothing more. Phainon had offered because Mydei had gotten hard, and he'd wanted to make Mydei feel better. And he’d only reciprocated because it just felt polite. None of that means that Phainon would be eager to actually *fuck*.

It makes the most sense to ignore his erection until Phainon leaves, and then take care of it alone.

Yet Phainon seems to have other plans. “You’re hard again,” he says, nodding at Mydei as he starts climbing from the tub.

“I’ll deal with it later.”

A hand tugs at his arm, keeping him from leaving the tub entirely. “Why not now? We can both go a second round.”

Mydei stares in awe at the limp cock already stirring to life in Phainon’s lap. “You’re getting hard again already?”

“I will be soon,” Phainon says, stroking himself languidly. “What do you think?”

It’s probably a bad idea. He’s already thinking about Phainon too much as it is; touching him more will likely only make it worse. But Mydei’s been through enough already today, and his will is weak. “I don’t think my jaw can handle another blow job right now.”

Phainon smiles. “No, not that. Come over here,” he says, pulling Mydei between his legs.

The gesture catches him off guard, and Mydei stumbles forward. He lands on Phainon, who has moved deeper into the water, crushing his body beneath him. Just as he’s about to apologize, he feels Phainon grab his cock. Mydei groans at the strong hand on him, and then at the feeling of something else hot and hard on his dick.

“Gods, yes,” Phainon says, rocking his hips up to meet Mydei. That confirms Mydei’s guess: that their cocks are now rubbing together under the hot water.

Phainon fumbles around the empty upper steps of the bath. “Where is that massage oil? Ah-ha!” he exclaims as he grabs the jar. “This is just what we need.”

All Mydei can do is watch as Phainon pours a generous amount of oil on his fingers and then brings them directly to their cocks, which are just barely under the water. They both immediately moan at the sensation.

“The oil helps, right?” Phainon says.

“Y-yeah,” Mydei manages to gasp out as he rocks against Phainon. The other man is pressed to the stone of the bath, but he doesn’t complain. Phainon thrusts his hips up to meet Mydei’s movements, rutting against his slick cock eagerly. They’re both fully hard now and clearly enjoying the friction.

“See, De, I told you this was a good idea,” Phainon says. “You feel so good against me.”

It does feel good—almost *too* good. Pressed so close together, Mydei finds it hard to look away from Phainon’s glowing blue eyes and his handsome face. The man’s lips are particularly tempting; they still look slightly reddened and puffy from the blow job earlier, and they’re parted now with Phainon’s heavy breathing.

Fuck, Mydei wants to kiss Phainon. He needs a distraction before he does something idiotic.

Only one thing is tempting enough to catch his attention. Mydei angles his head down and nips at the side of Phainon’s neck, in the spot where his choker only partially covers his yellow sunburst mark.

It makes Phainon yell. “Mydei!” he shouts, and ruts more frantically against him. “Gods, yes, more.”

With that encouragement, Mydei devotes himself to his task gladly. He bites and sucks at Phainon’s neck, savoring the salt of his skin and the tang of the black leather under his tongue. Phainon writhes under him, broken moans rendering him speechless.

Their bodies move faster and faster together, cocks still slick from the oil and now from their pre-cum, too. The tension builds in Mydei rapidly, and he feels himself losing control of his body as he gets closer to the edge.

To his surprise, Phainon comes first. The hot surge of cum against Mydei’s stomach and the other man’s choked exclamation confirms it. They’re pressed so close together that Mydei can *feel* the orgasm shudder through Phainon’s body.

That’s enough to make him come, too, adding his seed to the mess between them as he rocks a few final times and rides out the orgasm.

Unsurprisingly, Phainon breaks the silence. “That felt incredible.” He sighs happily, then groans. “Shit, we should probably get out of this water and empty the tub.”

A few minutes later, they’re resting by the pool drying off as the water drains away. Mydei should probably call for someone to come and clean it once Phainon leaves—he just hopes the cleaner doesn’t recognize the source of the mess.

“Are you feeling better now?” Phainon asks. He’s still completely naked, and using the towel Mydei gave him to dry off his hair.

“I feel fine, just tired.” In contrast, Mydei has his towel firmly on his lap, a reminder to his cock that it’s done for today. After two orgasms in quick succession and the intense fight against Nikador, he’s feeling totally drained.

Phainon nods at his statement. “That makes sense. I’ll leave after I get dressed.”

Perhaps he should avert his eyes to give Phainon some privacy, but after today Mydei feels justified watching him dress. It seems silly for Phainon to put on so many layers when he’s inside the bathhouse right now, and everyone outside the room will be wearing skimpy bathing outfits. It’s probably for the best, though; Phainon attracts attention no matter what, but it would be even worse if he went out there wearing one of those silky white garments that only went to the upper thigh.

Fuck, Mydei can’t think about that now. He saves the mental image for another day.

“Before I leave, I want to ask you something.” Phainon says.

Mydei nods, and Phainon continues. “You seem so set on having me inherit Nikador's Coreflame. Why?”

This again. Mydei wishes he'd refused to talk, though he suspects it wouldn't have worked on Phainon anyway.

"You're clearly the best inheritor for it." Phainon says. "The crown prince of Kremnos, immortal, a truer warrior than I could ever be… just look at what you sacrificed today. This Coreflame belongs to *you*."

Mydei crosses his arms and wishes he were wearing more than a towel around his waist. "I don't want it."

"But why?"

He groans. "You're not going to leave me alone until I explain, will you? Fine. It's…" Mydei has never expressed these feelings to anyone before. He's not even entirely sure what he's saying until the words leave his mouth. "What if I'm too much like Nikador?"

"Huh?"

"If I inherit Nikador's legacy, will I become like them? You said it yourself —I'm the obvious candidate to bear Nikador's will. Like it is my destiny to do so." Mydei clenches his fist. Destiny and prophecy—they are the forces that have taken everything from him. "I don't want the gods to decide my fate. And I don't want to inherit Strife and then be consumed by it."

As Mydei spoke, Phainon had finished dressing, and walked over to where Mydei sits. He crouches down and touches Mydei's arm gently. "That's what you're worried about? That you'll become some sort of… murderous immortal monster bent on destroying the world?"

"It's possible."

Phainon shakes his head. "Well, what about me? Maybe the Coreflame would turn me into a monster, too."

"No," Mydei says firmly. "Not you. You're too good, Deliverer. You would not be corrupted."

“Ha! I think you have too much faith in me,” Phainon says. “Regardless, Mydei, I am certain that you wouldn’t succumb to Nikador’s madness.”

“You can’t know that.”

Phainon’s expression is completely clear and assured as he says, “I can. I *do*. I see who you are, Mydeimos, much more than you realize. You might play the role of the haughty, bloodthirsty warrior prince well, but deep down, that’s not who you are.”

“Oh?” Mydei’s throat feels rough. “Who am I, then?”

Those bright eyes look into his own and stare as though they can see his soul. Mydei feels trapped in their intense, confident gleam. “You're the prince that refuses to take the throne. The Chrysos Heir who refuses the Coreflame of Strife. You didn't kill those Titankin back in Castrum Kremnos, even though they could've attacked at any moment. Do you think Nikador would've even considered doing those things for a second?”

Mydei doesn't know how to respond. He feels raw, like he's been dissected and seen for the first time in his life.

“You pretend not to care about any of this, but in truth, it's all to protect your people. Yes, you are honorable and a valiant warrior. You pursue glory in your own way. But I will never believe you would pursue Strife for its own sake.”

“You think too highly of me,” Mydei says.

Phainon smiles. “No, I don’t. You don’t trust yourself enough. In any case, I will still take Nikador's Coreflame, if that's what you wish. I just don't think you have anything to fear.”

“You should take it.”

“Alright then,” Phainon nods. “I will enter the trial tomorrow morning. Wish me luck.”

Mydei stands, too. “I’ll do it in person. I’llbe there to see you off.”

“No, no, you stay and rest,” Phainon says. “I already know I have your support. Now, go and get some rest. The next time you see me, I’ll be the newest demigod.”

Despite his confident words, there’s clear hesitation in Phainon’s voice, and even his smile looks artificial. Mydei resolves to see Phainon off tomorrow before his trial. He needs all the support he can get.

“Good luck, then, Deliverer. I have full confidence in you.”

Then they part, and Mydei falls into a dark, restless sleep.

Chapter End Notes

> Maybe one day, they'll work out that they have feelings for each other... but not today.
>
> I hope you liked it! Your comments are always appreciated. (I do my best to respond, but I'm a bit behind so my apologies.)
>
> This was more lightly edited than usual because of my time limitations before 3.1, so if you notice any errors, please let me know!
>
> Once again, thanks for reading!

End Notes

I hope you enjoyed the fic! Let me know what you think.

I haven't decided if the second chapter will include sex or not. Feel free to share your thoughts on that.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!